THE EUBOS SYSTEM

Book 1:

CODE NORMAL

RENEE GREENE

DeBokton Book

Find your hero within!

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Character cover art by Heather Preston

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To Doug, Heather, Kameron, Julia, Travis, Ryan, Daniel, Michael, and Joey, who developed the characters for this book.

Chapter 1: Carnival

Every other year, the Eubos system hosted a big carnival, featuring thousands of entertainers, food, vendors selling wares, games, rides, and sporting events. It was always held on Steron 12, one of the few planets dominated by humans. Since inhabitants of all the planets in the Eubos system came to the carnival, all types of unusual races were roaming around.

A very tall, thin, girl with long, dark hair stepped up on a stage and announced, “Prepare to be shocked! Prepare to be electrified! Prepare for Dancing Lightning! That’s me.” Music came on, and she began to dance around the stage with swords that shot electricity between them, lighting the stage in an array of sparks and electrifying the audience. She shimmered with an iridescent sheen as if she was sprinkled with copper dust. The audience stood mesmerized at her skill and grace.

Not everyone was taken in by her act. Carson didn’t even glance at Dancing Lightning. He walked straight

over to a booth. The lady selling wares there was rather unusual, seeming to be as much bunny as human. She was shaped like a human woman, but was covered with well-trimmed fur and had long, floppy bunny ears. Carson didn't mind. She could look like a three armed mole-rat as long as she had what he needed.

He looked normal for a human, actually better than normal. He had sandy blond hair, blue eyes, and seemed to be pretty strong.

"Do you have ostrich eggs?" he asked.

"No," the bunny lady answered. "I don't have any here, but I can get them. How many do you need?"

"A steady supply," Carson answered. "I need about three dozen today, but I will need to keep them coming." He stared at her and asked, "What are you?"

"I am Eira, an Angoran," she answered. "Why do you need so many ostrich eggs?"

"I am feeding an army," Carson answered. "Ostrich eggs taste good."

"I'll see what I can do," Eira responded. "I could have the eggs in three days."

"Tomorrow at the latest," Carson insisted.

They were interrupted by a small robot who was bouncing up and down, saying, "I am Jake! I am Jake! I have a boomerang!"

"That's very nice," Eira assured him. "But we are busy."

Jake continued, "My earpiece lets me hear everything. I'm very smart."

"Of course," Eira agreed. "Robots know a

tremendous amount of information.”

“I’m not a robot!” Jake insisted. “I’m a boy! Yes, I’m a boy, and I like super-heroes. One day I want to grow up to be one and save the universe.”

“That is very nice,” Eira assured him. “But we need to do some business.”

“I can do business,” Jake told her. “I can fight bad guys. I have a robot sidekick. He likes bananas.”

Eira sighed in frustration and told him, “I need to work.”

Eira and Carson again began haggling the price, unfortunately with constant interruptions from Jake.

Before they finalized, they noticed many guards start running toward something, or maybe away from something. Eira and Carson looked to see if something was chasing them, but saw nothing. The guards were probably running toward something. Whatever it was, it seemed to be in the city center. Jake took off after them.

Of course, people stopped and watched the guards run. Something was happening, something sinister. Still, it was Carnival, so people soon lost interest and went about their enjoyment. At least most people did. A shadow crept through the window of a building that guards were running into.

Carson again began bargaining with Eira, but they were again interrupted; that time by a lady screaming.

The guards that were left around the area ran toward the screaming lady, as did Dancing Lightning.

Dancing Lightning listened to the lady frantically explaining to the guards that her daughter had disappeared. Her daughter had been there a few minutes

before. The lady looked away to see why the guards were running, and when she looked back, her daughter was missing.

The guards asked what the daughter looked like and assured her that the girl had probably just wandered off.

The lady explained that her daughter was fifteen, average height, not too fat, not too thin, brown hair, brown eyes, and wearing a blue shirt and tan pants.

Dancing Lightning hit her earpiece and asked, “Monty, can you hack the security cameras and see what happened?”

“I’m already working on it,” Monty answered.

“Good,” she responded. “These guards are going to need help.”

Monty hacked the security cameras and saw that two men grabbed the girl and sprayed something in the air that masked their escape. He then hacked the large screens around the festival that were broadcasting events and put the footage of the kidnapping on them.

Dancing Lightning stepped in front of the guard, pointed to the screen, and ordered, “There are the men who kidnapped the girl. Go after them!”

“Who are you?” the guard asked. “How did you know how to find them, and how did you hack the system?”

“I’m Chernon,” she answered. “The Amazing Dancing Lightning.”

The guard looked up to her. She was tall and had two swords sheathed on her belt. “You are under arrest!” he ordered as he reached over and grabbed her wrists, but was immediately shocked.

Chernon didn't have time for a useless guard, so she ran off the direction the kidnappers had gone.

"Stop!" the guard called. "You are under arrest!" He called for other guards for back up.

"Search for them!" Chernon called to Monty. "Can you find them? I have guards on my tail."

"Give me a minute," Monty responded. "I'll see if I can put a facial tracker on the crowd and search through the security cameras." It took him several minutes, but he called back to her, "They are headed to the dock."

Chernon ran that direction. The guard shot her with a taser, but she pulled it out and kept running as if nothing had happened. As she neared the kidnappers, she noticed that she was on the big screens. Suddenly a sports announcer started announcing, "Now we see the lightning lady running from the guards. She's tall; she's fast; and she's likely to get away. Wait! Now we see that she is running toward men pulling a girl off. Who will get there first, the lightning lady or guards? But what about the crowd? Will they step in or stand – Wait! Was that a shadow? Did something just happen?"

Something definitely happened; the two men and the girl fell to the ground. As Chernon ran up, she noticed that someone had put out a trip wire that made them fall. Because of the fall, the men had let go of the girl, so Chernon pulled her swords and touched each of the men with them, shocking them so they shook and went unconscious.

The guards ran up and announced, "You are under arrest Lightning Girl! Come with us."

"What?" she exclaimed. "I just caught the kidnappers and rescued the innocent girl, and you are

arresting me? You should be thanking me. I just did your job for you.”

The officer looked sternly up at her, as she was over six feet tall. “You somehow know of the kidnappers and are likely working with them. You hacked the system, resisted arrest, shocked an officer, and killed two men.”

“I didn’t kill them,” Chernon defended. “They are merely unconscious. I shocked them. The volts were high, but the amps were low. They will be fine.”

The guard was not amused. “You are under arrest!” he insisted as he motioned for one of the other guards to cuff her. The guard walked up, but as he tried to put the metal cuffs on her, he shook and stepped back.

“Would you like another guard to try?” she taunted.

“I will myself,” the guard threatened. “I will use a grounding wire as I do.”

He did manage to cuff her. As he did, she saw she was still on the screens. “See what you get for helping?” she called to the people. Then she added, “Come see Dancing Lightning, the most amazing sword dancer in this system and many more. My next show is at...” She stopped herself. “The 5:00 show may be late, but I’ll have shows at 7:00 and 9:00 too. Dancing Lighting – don’t miss it!”

As the guards pulled her away, she called out, “This is injustice. I was...” She stopped as she heard another scream. She couldn’t help this time. Someone else would have to.

Of course other guards ran to see what was wrong. A mom and dad were screaming because their teenage son had disappeared. The boy had thought he heard

something and stepped behind a booth. Then suddenly, they heard him scream. When they went behind the booth, he was gone!

Eira wasn't happy, as it was her booth the commotion was around. If only she could find the boy.

As the guards questioned the people, a monkey-man ran over. He looked as if he was part orange gorilla, part human, and part monster. "Do you have something that belongs to the boy?" he asked.

"I do," the mother answered. "I am carrying his jacket for him."

The guard tried to say something, but the monkey-man ignored him. He grabbed the jacket, sniffed it, sniffed the air and ground, and went off following the trail. Eira followed him too.

Soon they appeared on the screen, as Monty thought the monkey-man and bunny-lady made a very interesting sight.

Both the monkey-man and Eira were faster than the guards, so they found the boy and his kidnappers first.

Eira immediately drew her blaster. "Let the boy go!" she demanded.

The kidnappers didn't negotiate. They went for their guns. Without hesitation, Eira shot one. The monkey-man tackled the other.

They freed the boy to the cheers of the crowd, who gathered around to congratulated them; but the guards showed up to arrest them.

"Arrest me?" Eira asked. "I saved the boy. It was on the screen. He was going for his gun."

"You drew first," the guard argued.

“They were kidnapping a boy!” she almost yelled.

“You’re still going down to the station,” the guard insisted. “Both of you.”

They took Eira and the monkey-man to the station and began to question them. Chernon was there too, and she wasn’t being very cooperative with the guards. They were ready to throw her in a cell when President Barkor, the leader of Steron 12, walked into the room.

“What is going on?” he asked.

“We are locking her up,” the guard answered.

President Barkor casually replied, “No, you aren’t. She is pardoned, so are the two over there.” He pointed to Eira and the monkey-man.

“What!” the guard exclaimed. He started to argue.

“They are pardoned!” Barkor insisted. “That is not up for debate. They are coming with me.”

“But...” the guard began, but Barkor gave a stern look and the guard quieted.

“At least let me send a guard for your protection,” the guard suggested more meekly.

President Barkor agreed, so a guard named Paul was assigned to go with him. Paul looked very strong, incredibly strong for a human.

Barkor took Eira, Chernon, Paul, and the monkey-man to his craft and they flew over to his office. Once they were all in and seated, Barkor began. “Eira, I saw what happened, and I need your help.”

“What do you need this time?” she asked.

Barkor looked around, making sure no one could hear and explained, “We have trouble. There have been

hundreds of kidnappings recently. My people are scared. We almost canceled Carnival, but that would have caused panic throughout the entire Eubos system. Carnival is the system's biggest event."

Eira nodded. "I know. What do you want me to do?"

Barkor didn't answer. He continued explaining, "There have been many kidnappings on my planet, all young, and all human."

Eira looked puzzled and asked, "Why would anyone want to kidnap humans? They serve absolutely no purpose. They don't produce angora wool to make soft clothing. Their hair is useless. They don't even taste good."

"Do you?" the monkey-man asked.

She raised an eyebrow and answered, "It's one of the reasons I carry a blaster."

Barkor continued, "My guards have not been able to find out who is behind the kidnappings. Then during Carnival today, K. L. Labs was robbed."

"That's where the guards were running!" Monkey-man chimed in.

"Yes," Barkor confirmed. "K. L. Labs is one of the leading scientific research companies in cloning technology. They were robbed."

Eira laughed and noted, "You don't think your guards will figure it out. You want us to find out who is behind the theft and kidnappings."

"Yes," Barkor agreed. "I've worked with you before, and I just saw what the lightning-lady and monkey-man can do. I need help."

"Maybe you should ask the shadow man who set the

trip wire," Chernon suggested. "He was slick, and didn't even land himself in jail."

A voice suddenly came from the corner of the room. "He already did. At least after I told him he should." The man stood up and approached them. He was hard to see until he came near, as he was wearing all black, with a black leather vest, and his skin was gray. The sunglasses completed the creepy look. "Call me Shade," he stated. "I told him that I'd take care of it, but he seems to think that we should get a group with some inhuman skills on this case."

Eira raised an eyebrow and asked, "Why are all of us inhumanly skilled people wanting to risk our lives to save humans?"

Shade leaned over her and answered, "You are a tradesman, and a good one; try, because there is good money in it for you."

She thought for a moment. "I am not a mercenary," she announced. Then she looked over at Barkor. "But I am a friend, and I will do this for you."

"I'm in," Monkey-man agreed. "When do we leave?"

"I'm not sure that I'm in," Chernon stated. "I am not an adventurer. I stand out in any crowd, so I can't sneak around and get information. I am not a fighter either. I am a performer. I have gigs scheduled every weekend for months."

"People's lives are at stake," Barkor coerced. "You are a fighter. I saw what you did to those kidnappers. You have great skills. Plus, you can go anywhere under the guise of going to perform. I need you. Think of the people's lives you can save. Children are being abducted."

Tears came to Chernon's eyes at the thought.

Shade leaned over to her and pointed out, "This is bigger than just this planet. I went into the building while the guards were searching it. Someone now has the ability to clone an army. If we don't stop whoever is behind this, the entire system could be overrun."

"Right," she mocked. "You can see the future."

He looked very serious and corrected, "No. I am a Damian hunter. You will not find a race more aware of its surroundings, and there is trouble, worse than you know."

His intensity somehow convinced her. "I'll talk to my technical man, Monty," she conceded. "If I go, he has to too."

Barkor nodded and urged, "Talk to him and give me an answer tonight. I want you to start immediately."

"Not until I'm done performing," she insisted. "But I'll talk to Monty."

When she went to talk to Monty, she found that there was another kidnapping while she was gone. That one wasn't stopped. Some poor child was taken. Chernon cried thinking of the family, how they must feel, and the poor, scared teenager. "We need to help stop what is going on," she decided. "Barkor needs us."

She explained everything to Monty, and he agreed that they should help. After her next performance, she and Monty approached Barkor.

He took all of them to a spaceship and introduced them to the pilot, Dakota, and the mechanic, Ji. Dakota appeared to be a normal human, but Ji didn't. He was seven feet tall, had bluish skin, talons on his bare feet, and three eyes, although the third one, the one on his

forehead, was shut, giving him a more normal look.

Barkor told all of them, “The ship is for your use. I don’t want you traveling on anything that looks official, as it would draw attention that you are working for me. Dakota has agreed to wait and take you where you need to go.”

“For a price,” Dakota added.

“I don’t need it,” Chernon stated. “Monty and I have our own ship.”

Barkor nodded and agreed, “I can tell Dakota he isn’t needed and put your ship on allowed-to-fly clearance. Right now I have all ships held because of the theft unless it is one of our military ships or dignitaries’ ships from other planets.”

“We need Dakota,” Eira responded. “We are likely to need two ships. We can work faster if we split up, and I don’t have a ship here.”

“Neither do I,” monkey-man added.

“Then it’s set. I will leave now and let you do what you need to,” Barkor told them. “I have Carnival to run. If you need me, call. For now, I suggest you stay on the ship where it is safe and make a plan. Something big is going on. I have sent all the information we have on the problem to Monty, since he asked for it. Good luck!” He nodded to them and left them to discuss their plans.

Before they started, Ji handed rubber clothing to Chernon and instructed, “You will wear this while on the ship. It is insulative. I have taken the liberty of insulating your room, as Barkor told me to expect you, but you need to wear this everywhere else.

She handed the clothes back and explained, “I wear

special clothes that Monty made me. My outfit is a multi-layer capacitor so I can produce electricity when none is in the air.”

Ji handed the clothes back and insisted, “Then I definitely want you to wear this, not what you have. We don’t need electrical spikes on the ship. No lightning. You must wear the rubber.”

They argued for a few minutes until Eira stopped them, insisting, “We need to figure out what we are going to do! We don’t have time to fight.”

As they all sat down around the council table, Ji whispered to Chernon, “You are wearing the rubber. That’s final.”

“What do we know?” Eira asked.

Dakota leaned back in his chair and asked, “Are we seriously taking orders from a bunny-lady?”

“I’m Eira,” Eira answered. “I am a trader. I have contacts, and I seem to be much more capable to lead than you humans.”

Dakota looked at the group and asked, “Are any of you human?”

“I am,” Monty answered. Then, he went back to what he was doing on the computer.

“I am,” Paul added.

“I’m not,” the monkey-man chimed in. “I’m Fangs.”

Dakota raised an eyebrow and noted, “Fangs the monkey-man? Now I’ve seen it all.”

Ji raised his hand. Nobody noticed.

They stopped the introductions because Monty interrupted. “I’ve been running comparisons on all the

kidnapped teenagers. It is interesting that they are all average. I mean all of them.”

“Isn’t that normal?” Dakota asked.

“No,” Monty explained. “If the choice of victims was random, there would be outliers. There would be teenagers chosen who had genetic mutations or who were exceptional in some area. Every victim was entirely average.”

Everyone stared at him.

Chernon pointed out, “That’s not much to go on. How do we know what to do when we have no information?”

“That’s step one,” Shade suggested. “We get information, and that means talking to people who might know. Do any of you have connections with mercenaries or criminals?”

“Maybe we should start with leaders of other worlds,” Eira suggested. “Does anyone have connections with them? We need to know if the problem is isolated.”

“We have to be discreet,” Chernon advised. “Barkor doesn’t want to cause alarm among the planets.”